

Nerve & Stress-Related Problems



Valerian
(*Valeriana officinalis*)

Most of us have little opportunity to escape from daily pressures, and consequently the nervous system is unable to recover its natural vitality. Long-term stress can lead to anxiety, nervousness, depression, insomnia, palpitations, and irritability. Herbal medicines can be wonderfully effective for nourishing the nervous system, calming and relaxing the mind, and gently stimulating or sedating the body. Headaches and migraine respond well to treatment with herbs, as can conditions directly affecting the nerves, such as neuralgia.

❗ Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Severe nerve, chest, or head pain
- Headache or pain that does not improve within 48 hours despite self-medication
- Loss of sensation or loss of movement
- Double vision
- Severe depression

🌿 Anxiety, Depression, & Tension

Many people have experienced lack of well-being and feelings of powerlessness that develop as stress, anxiety, and tension take hold. There is no instant answer, but a remarkable number of herbs can reduce these symptoms, and, by supporting the nervous system, gradually restore health.

Lemon balm, skullcap, and damiana are all calming herbs that ease physical tension and help maintain a balanced mental and emotional state. Lemon balm alleviates stress-related digestive problems, skullcap combats panic attacks, and damiana acts as a gentle “pick-me-up.”

Valerian has tranquilizing qualities.

Ginseng and Siberian ginseng are excellent for coping with stressful events such as competitive sports, examinations, or moving a household.

Ashwagandha is a supportive tonic herb, strengthening and encouraging recovery from long-term stress or chronic illness.

Lifestyle

When emotionally stressed, it is important to eat well, exercise regularly, and allow time for relaxation. Yoga and Tai Chi can be particularly helpful.

General Remedies

Herbs Lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*, p. 113), damiana (*Turnera diffusa*, p. 144), skullcap (*Scutellaria lateriflora*, p. 135)

Remedy Make an infusion using one of the herbs. Drink up to 2½ cups (600 ml) a day.

Herb St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106)

Remedy Take tablets or make an infusion and drink up to 2½ cups (600 ml) a day.

Note This remedy may take 2–3 weeks before there is a noticeable effect.

Digestive Problems due to Stress

Herb Lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*, p. 113)

Remedy Make an infusion with a handful of fresh leaves and ¾ cup (150 ml) water, or make an infusion with the dried herb. Drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day, or add the daily dose to a bath.

NOTE This remedy also calms palpitations and encourages sleep.

Panic Attacks & Headaches

Herb Skullcap (*Scutellaria lateriflora*, p. 135)

Remedy Make an infusion and drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Chronic Anxiety & Hyperactivity

Herb Valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*, p. 148)

Remedy Take 10 drops of tincture in water every hour for up to 2 weeks at a time.

Nervous Exhaustion, Muscle Tension, & Headaches

Herb Codonopsis (*Codonopsis pilosula*, p. 83)

Remedy Make a decoction and drink in equal doses during the day, or cook up to 25 g of the root a day in a soup or stew.

Short-term Stress

Herbs Ginseng (*Panax ginseng*, p. 118), Siberian ginseng (*Eleutherococcus senticosus*, p. 94).

Remedy Either take ginseng tablets, chew 0.5–1 g of root a day, or use it in cooking. Alternatively take 1–2 g of Siberian ginseng capsules up to twice daily.

Cautions Do not take for more than 6 weeks at a time. Do not give to children under 12. Do not take during pregnancy. Avoid drinks that contain caffeine.

Long-term Stress & Convalescence

Herb Ashwagandha (*Withania somnifera*, p. 152)

Remedy Make a decoction using 3 g of root to ¾ cup (150 ml) of water and take during the day, or chew the same amount of root.

🌿 Neuralgia (Nerve Pain)

Neuralgia is the pain caused by an irritated, damaged, or trapped nerve. It usually occurs in brief, severe bouts and can be felt shooting along the nerve. Although it is difficult to treat, the following remedies may bring relief to minor problems. St. John's wort is analgesic and antiviral, helping to relieve sciatica (pain caused by a trapped spinal nerve) and head pain. Cloves have an anesthetic effect, and peppermint eases pain. Try also the St. John's wort oil rub (see *Back Pain*, p. 313).

❗ **General caution** Seek professional advice if there is fever, or swelling of the gums with toothache.

General Remedies

Herbs St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106), lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108), clove (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97)

Remedy Apply neat St. John's wort infused oil to painful areas, or add 20 drops each of clove and lavender essential oil to 2 tbsp plus 2 tsp (50 ml) of St. John's wort infused oil and then apply every 2–3 hours as required.

Herb Peppermint (*Mentha x piperita*, p. 114)

Remedy Make an infusion with 25 g of herb to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and bathe the affected area. Alternatively, dilute 20 drops of essential oil in

2 tbsp plus 2 tsp (50 ml) of carrier oil and gently massage into the painful area.

Caution Do not use on children under 5.

Head Pain

Herb Clove (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97)

Remedy Mix ½ tsp of powder with water to make a thick paste and apply to the head.

Toothache

Herb Clove (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97)

Remedy Chew a clove or rub 1–2 drops of neat essential oil onto the affected tooth 2–3 times a day for up to 3 days.